

Gain and loss of parts

February 5th, 2004

Matters arising

- An interesting suggestion due to Casey Pegg:
 - When we ask whether something is in such-and-such place at such-and-such time, if the question is to have sense, it must be *relativised* to a sort.
 - One and the same object might be such that it was in place P at time T *qua lump*, but not *qua statue*.
 - If this is right, then sentence 5 of the original paradox ('There's only one statue-shaped object on the table at 11am) is really meaningless: we must instead ask: 'how many objects are there *qua statue*? How many *qua lump*? etc.'

- Argument that (in the case where I'm going to destroy and replace the arm) there are at least *two* objects on the table at 11am *qua statue*:
 - First of all, there's an object that will exist at 4pm *qua statue* but not *qua lump*.
 - But surely there will be a statue-shaped lump of clay on the table at 4pm. That object will exist at 4pm *qua lump*, so it's distinct from the first object.
 - It seems we must say that this second object is also on the table at 11 am *qua statue*. It would be arbitrary to say different things about the two objects.

Dion and Theon

- The story of Dion and Theon:
 - Dion's foot is going to be amputated tomorrow morning.
 - We introduce the name 'Theon' for that part of Dion that consists of all of him except for his foot.

- A. Dion exists today.
- B. Theon exists today.
- C. If Dion exists today, he will exist tomorrow.
- D. If Theon exists today, he will exist tomorrow.
- E. It is not the case that both Dion and Theon will exist tomorrow.

Denying B ('Theon exists today')

- In other words, Dion doesn't *have* a part which consists of all of him except for his foot.
- What principled basis could we give for saying this?
 - One possible view, misattributed by Burke to van Inwagen: deny that people really have any parts at all.
 - van Inwagen's real view: people have cells and atoms as parts. There are no undetached "torsos" or heads. Van Inwagen denies 'The Doctrine of Arbitrary Undetached Pars'.

Denying C ('Dion will exist tomorrow')

- Presumably if there are people at all—as there are, if I is true—there will be a person tomorrow whom we will then refer to as 'Dion'.
- The claim is that *it won't be the very same person*.

- What principled grounds could we give for this view?
 - One possible view: *Mereological Essentialism*—the view that nothing can be part of something at one time unless it is part of that thing at every time at which it exists. (So nothing can gain or lose parts.)
 - An even more radical view holds that nothing can really change *at all*.

Denying E

- If both Dion and Theon will exist tomorrow, it seems we must conclude that they will then be in the same place at the same time.
- Burke's challenge to this view: in virtue of what could coincident objects be of different sorts, or have different histories?

Denying D (Burke's view)

- It seems odd to think that a thing confined to a certain region of space could cease to exist even if nothing changes within that region of space.

- Burke's argument: (1) Proper parts of persons are not persons. So Theon is not a person. (2) 'Personhood is an essential property': Once a person, always a person. So Theon is never a person. But (3) if Theon were to survive the amputation, Theon would become a person. So Theon doesn't survive.

- A corresponding view about the statue and the clay paradox: 4 is false. The original lump of clay doesn't survive.
- Question: what principled reason can we give for deciding whether a given change forces something to go out of existence in this way?
- Gollyswoggles.